



Ashtavakra Gita — Chapter 3

Verse 3.1

Ashtavakra: "You know now that you are one, whole, and cannot be destroyed. So how can gaining more wealth still give you any pleasure?"

This chapter begins with a surprising question.

Janaka, the student, has just recognized his true nature. One might expect Ashtavakra to congratulate him or explain the realization further. Instead, he asks,

"You know now that you are one, whole, and cannot be destroyed. So how can gaining more wealth still give you any pleasure?"

At first, the question seems to be about wealth. But it is really about something much deeper.

If you truly know yourself to be whole, what is it that still reaches for more?

Wealth is only an example. You could replace it with success, recognition, possessions, status, or praise. The question would remain exactly the same.

Ashtavakra is not criticizing Janaka. Nor is he saying that wealth is wrong. He is inviting Janaka to look carefully at his own experience. Is the realization merely something he understands, or has it transformed the way he lives?

It is a question worth asking ourselves as well. We may understand these teachings intellectually, yet still find ourselves believing that the next achievement, the next possession, or the next moment of approval will finally complete us.

Perhaps that doesn't mean the understanding is false. It simply means that understanding and living are not always the same.

So don't hurry past this first verse.

If you are already whole, what is it that still reaches for more?

You don't have to answer the question immediately.

Just let it stay with you.

Verse 3.2

Ashtavakra: "When you do not know yourself, you chase after things, sure they will make you happy. It is like seeing a shining shell on the beach and grabbing at it, mistaking it for silver."

In the last verse, Ashtavakra asked why we still reach for more, even after we have seen the truth. Here he tells us where all that reaching comes from.

It comes from not knowing yourself.

Look at what he says. When you do not know what you are, you go after things — money, praise, pleasure — certain that they will finally make you happy. But you are mistaking them for something they are not. He gives a small, perfect picture of it. A person walks along the beach, sees a shell catching the light, and thinks, "*Silver!*" — and reaches for it in greed. But it was only a shell. The silver was never there.

That is what we do with almost everything we chase. We see a thing shining — a bigger house, a person's approval, a good feeling — and we are sure our happiness is inside it. So we reach. And when we finally have it, the shine fades, because the happiness was never really in the thing. We only thought it was, because we did not know ourselves.

Notice how gentle this is, underneath. Ashtavakra is not calling you foolish for wanting. He is showing you why the wanting never ends: you have been reaching for silver that was always just shell. The moment you know yourself — the whole, quiet awareness that needs nothing — the desperate reaching begins to loosen on its own.

So the next time you feel that strong pull toward something, you might ask, quietly: is this silver, or is it shell? And who is the one that already lacks nothing?

Verse 3.3

Ashtavakra: "This whole world rises and falls like waves on the sea. Once you have seen, 'I am that sea,' why do you still run around like someone poor and in need?"

Ashtavakra now gives us one of the great images of the whole book.

Look at the sea. Waves rise, and waves fall. There are big waves and small ones, still days and wild days. But every wave is only the sea, lifting and falling for a moment. No wave is separate from the water. No wave is ever truly lost.

He says the whole world is like this. Everything that happens — every event, every person, every thought and feeling — rises and falls like a wave. And you? You are not one small wave, tossed about among the others. You are the sea itself. All of it is rising and falling within you.

Now hear his question. Once you have seen this — *"I am that sea"* — why do you still run around like someone poor, like someone who is missing something and must chase it down?

This is the gap again. A wave cannot be richer or poorer than another; it is all water. The sea is not missing anything. And yet, even after glimpsing that you are the sea, the old thin fear of not having enough returns, and off you go, chasing.

Ashtavakra is not shaming that. He is inviting you to catch yourself in the act. The next time you feel that anxious, hurrying, not-enough feeling — the running — you might pause and remember the sea. You are not a small thing that has to grab at the waves. You are the wide water in which they all come and go.

Verse 3.4

Ashtavakra: "You have heard that you are pure awareness, more beautiful than anything in this world. After hearing that, will you still go on chasing the body's crude pleasures?"

In the last verse, Ashtavakra asked a really interesting question. He asked, if you've truly seen that you're the sea, then why are you still running around like a beggar? And now he takes that

same point a little further. He starts looking at the gap itself, and he begins with one of the strongest examples of that gap, which is desire.

Now, notice exactly what he's saying here. He's saying you've heard the truth about yourself. You've heard that you're pure awareness, and you've heard that nothing you could possibly chase is more beautiful or more complete than what you already are. And yet, even after hearing that, the old pull toward pleasure is still there. The body's cravings are still there. The hunger for sensation is still tugging at you.

He's pointing to something that's actually very simple, and honestly, a little humbling. Just hearing the truth doesn't automatically change what pulls you.

A lot of us expect it to. We read a book like this one, something in it really resonates, and quietly, almost without noticing, we assume the work is finished. Then an old craving shows up again, just as strong as it always was, and suddenly we feel confused. Or maybe we feel ashamed. We start thinking, "Well, maybe my understanding wasn't real after all."

Ashtavakra is saying, don't do that. Just look at what's happening honestly, without the shame.

The words entered your ears. But the pull lives somewhere deeper. It lives in the body. It lives in years of habit. And that part hasn't heard the news yet.

So when desire comes up after a moment of genuine understanding, it doesn't mean your understanding was worthless. It simply means that hearing is only the beginning. What you've heard now has to soak in slowly, the way rain gradually soaks into hard ground.

And because of that, you don't have to fight the pull. But you don't have to obey it either. You can simply see it clearly and say, "Here's the old habit, still moving, in someone who has heard the truth."

And that clear, unashamed seeing—that's where the soaking begins.

And as we'll see in the next verse, desire isn't the only old habit that continues to linger.

Verse 3.5

Ashtavakra: "When a wise person has seen that they live in all beings, and all beings live in them, it is astonishing that the feeling of being a separate someone can still go on."

So, we've already seen that desire is one habit that can keep going even after the truth has been heard. Now Ashtavakra points to another habit, and this one goes even deeper.

It's the feeling of being a separate someone.

Just think about what the wise person has actually seen. They've looked into their own nature, and they've discovered that it isn't limited or fenced in anywhere. The same awareness that's looking out through their eyes is looking out through every pair of eyes. They're in all beings, and all beings are in them, in the same way that every wave is in the sea, and the sea is in every wave.

And yet, the next morning they wake up, and the old feeling is still there. *Me*. This one person, inside this one body, facing everyone else.

Ashtavakra finds that astonishing. And notice something important here. He doesn't say it's disgraceful. He doesn't call it stupid, and he doesn't treat it as a sign of failure. He simply marvels at it. It's a bit like noticing that the moon still seems to follow your car, even though you know perfectly well that it isn't.

That's really worth taking in, because this sense of being a separate "me" is probably the oldest habit we have. It was there before every other habit. It formed before we could even speak. So of course it doesn't disappear the moment the truth is seen. It just starts up again by itself, like a machine that keeps humming for a while even after you've switched the power off.

So you don't have to fight this feeling, and you don't have to pretend it isn't there. When it appears—and it will—you can simply notice it with that same gentle astonishment: *There it is again. The little me, still humming.*

And the interesting thing is, whatever is noticing it is already wider than it.

And this stubborn little hum of "me" also explains the next thing Ashtavakra is about to marvel at.

Verse 3.6

Ashtavakra: "It is astonishing that someone who has reached the highest oneness, whose whole aim is freedom, can still be ruled by lust and held back by it."

You might be wondering why Ashtavakra comes back to the subject of desire when he already talked about it a couple of verses ago. But if you look carefully, you'll see that this is actually a different kind of astonishment.

Back in verse 3.4, the person had only heard the truth. And that's not so surprising, really. Just hearing something doesn't necessarily remove all the old habits and attractions. Those old pulls can still be there.

But now we're looking at someone who's gone much further. They've reached the highest sense of oneness. They understand very deeply. More than anything else in life, they want freedom.

And yet, desire still gives the orders. And they still follow them.

That's what Ashtavakra finds so astonishing. It's not that understanding is missing. It's that understanding and craving can exist in the very same person at the same time. It's almost as if the mind has the deepest truth sitting in one room, while in another room an old desire quietly picks up the phone, and the whole body answers the call.

You can actually see this in ordinary life, can't you? Someone can understand everything about their own anger and still lose their temper. A doctor can know exactly what smoking does to the body and still smoke. So even deep, genuine understanding doesn't automatically take the driver's seat.

Now, Ashtavakra isn't saying that this person's realization is false. That's not his point. He's simply holding up the strangeness of the situation so that we stop being naïve about ourselves. If even someone who is completely devoted to freedom can be pulled off the road by old desires, then it's really no scandal when it happens to us. It's simply a reminder of how powerful these old currents are, and how honest we have to be in recognizing them.

So if you ever find yourself in a situation where you understand something completely and still

act against your own understanding, let this verse stay with you. You're not uniquely weak. You've simply run into the same astonishing gap that Ashtavakra saw.

And learning to see that gap without making excuses, and without falling into despair, that's what gradually begins to close it.

And then Ashtavakra is going to show us that desire still has one more surprise waiting for us.

Verse 3.7

Ashtavakra: "It is astonishing that someone grown weak with age, who knows very well that the flaring up of desire is the enemy of clear knowing, still hankers after pleasure — even in his last days."

Here's desire's last surprise, and it's a sobering one.

Ashtavakra asks you to picture someone near the end of life. Their body is worn out. There isn't much strength left. They can hardly enjoy pleasure anymore. And more than that, they know from a lifetime of experience that every time craving comes up, it clouds the clear knowing they care about most.

And still, the craving continues.

The mind still reaches for pleasure, even when it can't really enjoy it anymore.

Now, that tells you something important about craving. It isn't really about enjoyment. If it were, it would fade when the enjoyment faded, just like your appetite fades once your stomach is full.

But that isn't how craving works.

Craving is more like a groove that's been worn into the mind through years of repetition. And once that groove is there, it doesn't need a reason to keep going. It can keep running on empty. It can outlive your ability to enjoy. It can outlive your health. It can even outlive your belief that indulging is worth it.

So we should be gentle with this, both in other people and in ourselves.

When you see an older person still grasping after things, or when you notice in yourself a wanting that keeps going long after the pleasure has become stale, what you're seeing isn't wickedness.

It's momentum.

At the same time, we should also be honest about what that means.

If craving doesn't fade on its own, then simply waiting for it to fade isn't really a plan. The passing years won't do the work for you.

The groove is only softened by what Ashtavakra has been pointing to all along: knowing yourself as the one in whom all of this wanting arises and passes away.

So there's no need to wait for some quieter stage of life before taking these teachings seriously.

That quiet doesn't come from the calendar.

It comes from seeing.

And that's exactly why the next verse is so strange—and so beloved.

Verse 3.8

Ashtavakra: "It is astonishing that someone with no attachment to this world or the next, who can tell the lasting from the passing, and who longs for freedom — should still be afraid of freedom."

Of all the surprising things in this chapter, I think this one is probably the most gentle and touching.

Ashtavakra is describing someone who's already come a long way on the path. They're no longer attached to the things of this world, and they're not even chasing rewards in some future world. They can clearly see the difference between what's lasting and what's temporary. And freedom is the one thing they truly want.

But then something unexpected happens.

As freedom comes close, they're afraid of it.

Now, how can you want something so deeply and be afraid of it at the same time? It sounds like a contradiction. But if you really look at your own experience, you might find it's actually one of the most human things there is.

The reason is that freedom, in this teaching, means the end of that small sense of "me" that you've been carrying your whole life. It's the same stubborn sense of "me" that we talked about back in verse 3.5.

And even if that little "me" has felt cramped, even if it's suffered a great deal, it's still familiar. You know its worries. You know its habits. You know its story. So the idea of letting it dissolve into something limitless can feel less like gaining everything and more like losing the only self you've ever known.

So the seeker arrives at the very doorway they've been walking toward all this time... and they hesitate.

If you've ever noticed this in yourself—this strange reluctance right at the edge of letting go, this tendency to pull back just when peace comes close—please don't take that as proof that you're not ready, or that your longing isn't sincere.

Ashtavakra saw this in advanced seekers.

The fear isn't a flaw in your longing. It's simply the last movement of the separate self. And it appears precisely because you've come so close.

You don't have to force yourself through the door.

For now, it's enough just to notice that the one who's afraid is the very one you're being freed from.

See that gently, without fighting it, and you'll find that the fear begins to lose its footing all by itself.

Verse 3.9

Ashtavakra: "Whether he is celebrated or tormented, the wise person rests in the awareness of his own supreme nature, and is neither delighted nor cast down."

With this verse, the chapter really starts to turn. Up to this point, Ashtavakra has been pointing to the gap. Now he begins to describe the person in whom that gap has completely closed.

And he starts with two opposite experiences.

One day, this person is celebrated. They're honored, applauded, surrounded by admiration.

Another day, they're tormented. They're attacked, insulted, or made to suffer.

Life brings both of these. It doesn't matter who you are. Everyone experiences praise at times and pain at times.

But through both of those experiences, something in this person doesn't move.

They remain aware of what they truly are. Because of that, they're not lifted up by praise, and they're not brought down by pain.

Now, be careful not to misunderstand this.

Ashtavakra isn't describing someone who's become cold or emotionally numb. He's not talking about someone who's like a stone, where honors and insults just bounce off because there's nothing alive inside.

That's not the point.

He's describing someone whose sense of what they are no longer depends on what's happening to them.

For most of us, though, that dependence runs very deep.

When someone praises us, we quietly grow inside.

When someone criticizes us, we quietly shrink.

Our sense of self is expanding and contracting all day long, almost like a lung that's constantly

breathing in the opinions of other people and the events of our lives.

The wise person's sense of self has stopped breathing that air.

They know themselves as the awareness in which both celebration and torment appear.

It's the same image of the sea that we've come back to before.

Pleasant waves rise.

Violent waves rise.

And then they both fall.

The waves are real, and they're fully felt.

But the water itself isn't made greater by one wave or smaller by another.

So this steadiness isn't a wall that's been built against life.

It's simply what remains when there's nothing left that needs to be defended.

Now, you may only experience this once in a while.

Maybe criticism lands, and for just a moment, nothing inside you shrinks.

If that happens, treasure those moments.

They're small previews of exactly what Ashtavakra is describing here.

And in the next verse, he's going to tell us how this kind of steadiness is even possible.

Verse 3.10

Ashtavakra: "The great soul watches his own body going about its actions as if it were someone else's. How then could praise or blame disturb him?"

In the last verse, we saw that the wise person isn't moved by praise or by torment. Now Ashtavakra shows us why. And it's important to see that this isn't about willpower. It's not that

they're trying to stay calm. It comes from a shift in where they stand.

He says that the great soul watches their own body in action as if it were someone else's.

Just think for a moment about how you respond when you hear praise or blame about another person. If someone tells you your neighbor did something well, or did something badly, you can listen with interest. You might agree or disagree. But those words don't really enter you, because they're about someone else. Nothing inside you swells or shrinks.

Now compare that with what happens when the very same words are about you. Suddenly they land somewhere soft. So the difference isn't in the words themselves. The difference is one small belief: *this body, these actions—that's me*.

The wise person has seen through that belief. They still act. The body still works, still speaks, still makes mistakes. Sometimes it does things well, and sometimes it doesn't. But they watch all of that activity the way you would watch the neighbor—with interest, even with care, but from a quiet step back.

So when praise comes, it's praise of something they can see, but are not. And when blame comes, it's exactly the same.

Now, this might sound a little distant. It might seem as though such a person has somehow abandoned their own life. But actually, it's the opposite. The only thing that ends is the swelling and shrinking. Care is still there. Responsibility is still there. What falls away is the constant flinching.

You can even get a small taste of this yourself. The next time you find yourself replaying something you said and feeling the sting of how it came across, try watching that whole scene as if the person speaking were someone you love—someone who's simply doing their best.

Then notice what happens. Notice how the sting begins to soften when the watcher takes that small step back.

And that small step back is exactly the direction Ashtavakra has been pointing all along. In the next part, he takes that insight even further than we might expect.

Verse 3.11

Ashtavakra: "Seeing this world as a passing appearance, and having no stake in it, how should a steady person feel fear — even when death draws near?"

So, we saw that praise and blame can't really disturb someone who's able to watch their own body from a step back. Now Ashtavakra takes that same step back all the way to its furthest point.

And then he asks a bigger question. If praise can't touch someone like that, then what about death?

His answer really rests on two things. First, the steady person sees this world as a passing appearance. It's something that arises and shows itself, like the shell that seemed to be silver, or like the waves on the sea. You experience it, but it doesn't have any solid, lasting substance of its own. Second, because they see it that way, they don't have a stake in it. There's nothing here they're holding on to as *mine, forever*.

Now think about what fear actually needs in order to exist. Fear always needs something that could be lost. It might be a possession, a reputation, a relationship, or a future. And underneath all of those, it's this body and this life. Fear is really the mind trying to guard what it thinks it owns.

But if nothing is being held, then what is there to guard?

For someone who knows themselves as the sea, death is simply something that happens to a wave. The wave is real as an appearance. It rises, it moves, and eventually it falls. But when it falls, no water is lost. What they truly are was never the wave, so even if its ending is very near, it isn't their ending.

Now, we should be honest here. Just reading this isn't going to remove the fear of death. That fear is old, and it's deep. Pretending it's gone would just be another mask. Ashtavakra isn't asking you to pretend. He's showing you where fearlessness actually comes from. It doesn't come from courage. It doesn't come from effort. It comes from seeing what you are.

For now, it may be enough just to notice the fear when it shows up, and to ask, very gently, who is it that feels threatened?

The one who can watch even that fear... that's what these verses are pointing to.

Verse 3.12

Ashtavakra: "Who can be compared to the great soul whose mind stays free of wanting even in disappointment, and who has found contentment in knowing himself?"

So now Ashtavakra asks a question that almost sounds like admiration, and really, it is admiration. He's asking, who could possibly be compared to a person like this?

But notice where he places their greatness. He doesn't point to fearlessness in the face of death, even though that's what he was just talking about. Instead, he points somewhere much quieter. He points to the way this person's mind behaves in disappointment.

Now, disappointment is usually the moment when wanting shows its real strength. Something has gone wrong. What we hoped for didn't happen. And in that gap between the way things are and the way we wanted them to be, the mind immediately gets to work. It wants the situation undone. It wants things to be different. It wants some kind of compensation. It wants someone to blame. Disappointment is where desire tends to dig in the deepest.

So look carefully at what's being said here. This person's mind remains free of wanting even in that moment. Not because they've forced themselves not to have wishes, but because their contentment was never resting on the outcome in the first place. Their contentment rests on knowing themselves. And that knowing doesn't become greater when life goes well, and it doesn't break apart when life goes badly. It's simply there, like the ground beneath your feet.

That's why Ashtavakra says no one can really be compared to such a person. Every other kind of satisfied person is satisfied because of something—because of health, success, love, comfort, or whatever it may be. And if satisfaction depends on those things, then it can disappear when those things disappear. But a contentment that depends on nothing has no rival, because it's not even playing the same game.

Now, most of us aren't there yet, and that's perfectly all right. But this verse gives us a very practical mirror to look into. The next time disappointment comes—and it will—a plan falls through, or a hope quietly comes to an end, just watch your own mind. See how quickly

wanting rushes in to fill that gap.

And if you can simply notice that rush without immediately following it, that's already a beginning.

And that prepares us for the next statement, which is both very simple and, at first, a little strange.

Verse 3.13

Ashtavakra: "A steady person knows that what he sees is, by its very nature, nothing at all. How then should he look on one thing as something to grasp, and another as something to push away?"

You know, there's a quiet activity going on in us almost all the time. It's so constant that we hardly ever notice it. The mind is always sorting.

It's saying, "This is good. Move toward it. Get it. Keep it." Or, "That's bad. Stay away from it. Refuse it. Get rid of it." Every experience that comes to us gets stamped almost instantly: *grasp* or *reject*. Even as you're reading this, something in the mind is probably doing exactly that. "I like this idea." "I don't like that one." It's constantly sorting.

Now, Ashtavakra says that the steady person has stopped sorting. And then he tells us why, in words that can sound a little shocking the first time you hear them. He says it's because they know that what they see is, by its very nature, nothing at all.

That doesn't mean the world isn't experienced. That's not what he's saying. He's pointing back to what he's been saying all along, ever since the examples of the shell and the silver, and the waves on the sea. What appears doesn't have any solid, independent substance of its own. It's appearance. It's real as appearance, but empty as substance. The silver you reached for was never actually in the shell, and the poison you tried to push away was never in it either.

Grasping and rejecting look like opposites, but they're really two hands of the same mistake. They both begin with the belief that the thing in front of you truly contains happiness or truly contains threat. And when that belief falls away, both hands relax at the same time. Not

because the person has become passive, but because there's nothing in the appearance for those hands to close around.

Now, you can't force yourself to stop sorting. If you try to reject your rejecting, that's just more of the same process. But you can start to notice it. Maybe today, once or twice, you simply catch that stamp coming down: *want this, not that*. Just notice it happening.

And then see something very important.

The one who sees the sorting is not the sorter.

Rest there for a moment, and then the next verse will show you what life feels like when the sorting begins to grow quiet.

Verse 3.14

Ashtavakra: "For one who has dropped attachment, who is free of divided seeing and free of desire, a pleasure that comes of its own accord brings neither pain nor excitement."

So, what happens to enjoyment once grasping and rejecting have started to grow quiet? Well, this last verse of the chapter answers that question, and I think the answer is actually much gentler than we might expect.

Enjoyment doesn't disappear. It just changes its character.

Ashtavakra talks about a kind of pleasure that comes on its own. It's not something you chase, or arrange, or try to squeeze out of life. It just arrives, the way sunlight falls on your face when you step outside. And he says that for someone who has let go of attachment, that kind of experience is neither painful nor pleasurable.

Now, at first, that sounds a little strange. You might wonder, "How can pleasure not be pleasurable?"

What he means is that it no longer carries the old emotional charge.

For most of us, pleasure is rarely just pleasure. Before it arrives, there's craving. While it's

happening, there's clinging. And afterward, there's often a little ache—the wish to have it again, the fear of losing it, or the disappointment when it fades. That's usually what we mean by pleasure. It's wrapped up in all of those extra movements of the mind. And in that sense, pain and pleasure always come together as a pair.

The free person has stepped outside that pair.

When something delightful comes, it's received fully and simply. And when it goes, it goes. Nothing inside them reaches after it, so nothing inside them is torn when it comes to an end. The sunlight is warm, and then a cloud passes over, and both are perfectly all right.

Now notice how beautifully this brings the whole chapter full circle.

At the beginning, Ashtavakra is almost marveling that we keep chasing pleasure even after hearing the truth. And by the end, we discover something surprising. When the chasing stops, pleasure isn't lost at all. Whatever comes by itself can still be enjoyed—perhaps even more completely than before—because you're no longer asking it to complete you.

So nothing has to be renounced, and nothing has to be pursued.

Things come, and things go, and you remain.

Let's just let the chapter end there, quietly.

What remains—the one who stays while everything else comes and goes—is exactly where the teaching turns next.